

Philippine Women's Elite 2024

2-3-1 Coaching Program

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I. DEFINITIONS & PLAYER ROLES

A. Strong Side: Strong side (a.k.a. “on” side) refers to the side of the player formation (left or right) that the puck is on. If the puck is on the left side of the pool, then the left Forward and left Wing are referred to as “Strong Forward” and “Strong Wing”.

B. Weak Side: Weak side (a.k.a. “off” side) refers to the side of the player formation (left or right) that the puck is not on. If the puck is on the left side of the pool, then the right Forward and right Wing are referred to as “Weak Forward” and “Weak Wing”.

C. Forwards: Forwards (F) work closely together (less than 1M apart), and are generally shoulder to shoulder, or slightly staggered at the front of the formation. Both Forwards should be on the bottom at the same time, every time, working together. Forwards maintain Left/Right positioning in relationship to each other and will be referred to as Strong Forward (SF) and Weak Forward (WF) according to where the puck is located in the pool at any given time.

1. Forwards create chaos on defense by interrupting the opposing team’s formation and back-picking.

2. Forwards should be positioned in front of the Strong Wing to receive passes and drive the puck Forward.

3. Forwards must also be prepared to swim fast and meet the Weak Wing out in open pool anytime a cross pool swim (a.k.a. “swing” or “switch”) is initiated.

D. Center: The Center (C) controls the speed and direction of the play. Center maintains a position just behind the Forward line, or 30° back from the Strong Wing. If the puck is in open pool (not decidedly left or right) the Center controls the direction of the play by taking possession of the puck and distributing it to the left or right sides of their formation.

1. Center covers the Stopper when they engage.

2. Center may swim to take vertical space but should always distribute to Wings for lateral or diagonal cross-pool movements, instead of swimming the puck laterally themselves.

3. Center should not position themself on the wall.

E. Stopper: The Stopper (S) or “goalie” plays behind the mid-line and quickly replaces any mid-line (Wing or Center) position where the puck/opponent gets through. The Stopper should “smash” the puck and drive it forward to allow for the Center to more easily rotate or cycle behind.

1. The Stopper should expect at times to be momentarily “alone” or without teammates during their push and must maintain possession of the puck, while the Forward and mid-line reset for the next effort.

2. The Stopper is not limited in their passing options or movements, they may choose initiate open play to get the puck out into space to relieve pressure.

F. Wings: Wings (W) swim the puck. Wings maintain Left/Right positioning in relationship to each other and will be referred to as Strong Wing (SW) and Weak Wing (WW) according to where the puck is in the pool at any given time. If the puck is in open pool (not decidedly left or right) both Wings should set up 30° back from the Center and remain ready to swim the puck to their side of the pool.

1. Wings should avoid crossing the formation.

a) In the case that Weak Wing does have to drive onto the “wrong” side, they should distribute the puck quickly to a “correct” Strong side teammate and immediately reset back to the Weak position.

G. Strong Wing: Strong Wing (SW) is the Wing on the side of the puck. Strong Wing is responsible for driving play on their side of the pool and may pass to the Forward line, Center, or Stopper to maintain team possession. Strong Wing should never let the puck go around their outside (between them and their Strong wall).

1. When the Strong Wing needs to breath, or is beaten by opponents, their position will be replaced by the Stopper.
   a) Center should avoid taking Strong Wing position on the wall, and instead swims back to cover the Stopper position.
   b) Strong Wing immediately cycles back and readies themself to re-enter play with the Center.
   c) Strong Wing and Center re-enter play in standard 30° formation and the Stopper once again falls back, ready cover any of the mid-line.

H. Weak Wing: Weak Wing (WW) is the Wing not on the side of the puck. A Weak Wing positions themselves 30° back from the Center and must remain diligent, ready to swim hard and fast. When the team is initiating open play, the Weak Wing may receive a quick pass from the Center, or a pass from the Stopper.

1. If in doubt, both Wings should play the Weak Wing position, 30° back from the Center.
2. The Weak Wing’s #1 priority is that they must never let the opponent take the puck around their outside (in the open space between them and their Strong wall).
3. The Weak Wing is constantly adjusting their position based on which team has possession of the puck and how the other team’s Weak side is staged.
   a) On defense, the Weak Wing must aggressively intercept or shepherd the other teams swing all the way across the pool to their Strong side. Do not allow the opponent to turn up pool (toward our goal) or to get around the outside.
4. Once in possession of the puck, the Weak Wing may only travel vertical or continue to their Strong side.
   a) When the Weak Wing gains possession, they are never allowed to swim or pass back to the side of the pool the puck just came from.
   b) Even when resistance is met, the traveling Wing must ensure the puck continues to their Strong side of the pool.
5. The Stopper covers the Weak Wing if the opponent gets past them and Weak Wing immediately swims back fast, to assist as needed with defense.
6. When the team is making an attempt at the goal, the Weak Wing may move in front of the Center, to seal the puck in the area of the goal tray, not allowing the opponent to swim out towards their side or cross the goal.

DIAGRAM 1-1
Strong Side LEFT

Strong Side RIGHT

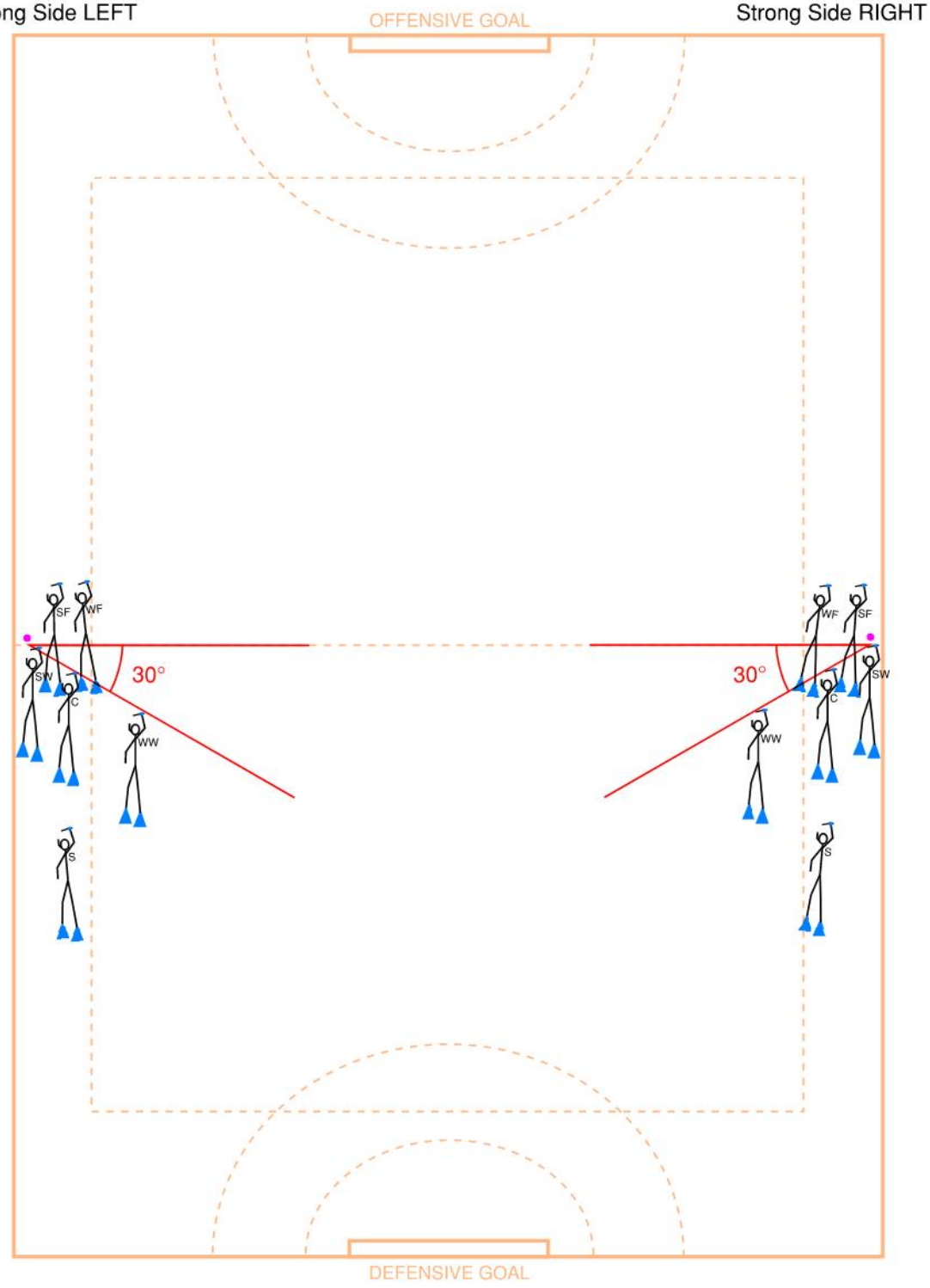
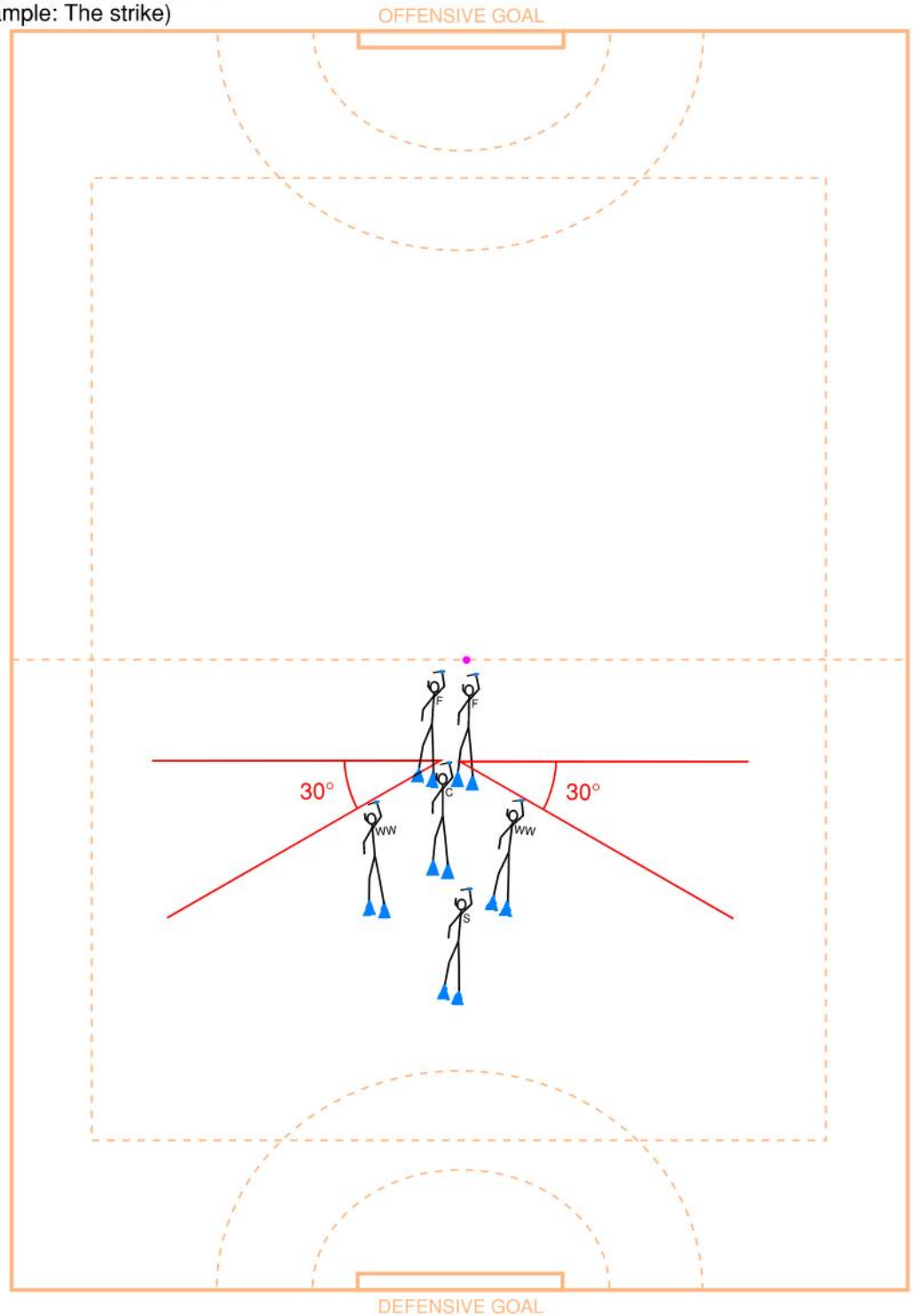


DIAGRAM 1-2
No established side of play
(example: The strike)



II. VERTICAL/CHANNEL

A. Vertical or Channel play will be the backbone for all other strategy. We will begin with drills that move the puck Forward, within the vertical space of our team, without losing it off-the-top of the formation or wide to the opponents

1. It is not necessary to be near a wall to play channel style, but the walls provide a Strong defensible space, with strict positioning guidelines. The wall channel is therefore the easiest position from which to learn to control your vertical space and will be the initial focus of our discussions.

2. Once we can control the vertical channel, we get to choose the speed of the game, when to play defensively, when to play offensively, and when to take the puck into open space and swim.

3. If an opponent's back line does not have to commit to stopping our vertical drive, they will always be available to stop our open play.

4. We can control the vertical channel by keeping the puck in the mid-line (or Center) of our formation as much as possible.

B. Vertical/Passing Patterns

1. Strong Wing passing options (see diagram 2-1):

a) Straight ahead to the Forward line.

(1) All Forward shots are followed-up with a Strong swim to ensure the opponent is trapped between the Strong Wing and Forward in a pinch.

b) To the Center.

(1) This pass should be done at the beginning of the dive when the Strong Wing is fresh.

(2) When we are playing vertical, the Wing should be prepared stay down to either drive Forward with the Center and/or receive the puck back from Center.

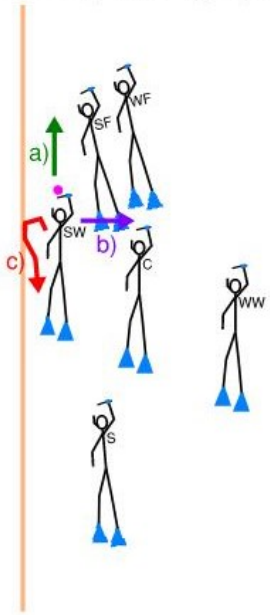
c) Curl and pass back to the Stopper.

(1) Stopper will indicate where they want the puck by swimming tight to the Wing or by leaving some space. Always pass to the Stoppers stick.

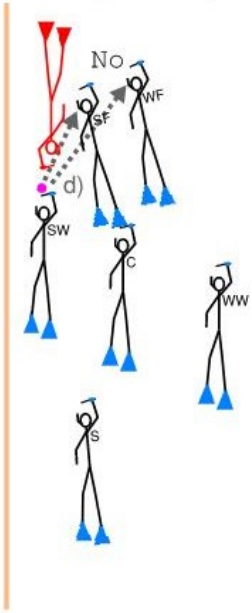
(2) In this instance, Strong Wing then surfaces and cycles back, ready to re-enter play behind Stopper resuming standard 30° mid-line formation.

d) Under no circumstances may the Strong Wing pass diagonally across a defender.

DIAGRAM 2-1
Strong Wing Passing Options



Never pass diagonally across a defender



2. Strong Forward passing options (See diagram 2-2):

a) Straight ahead

(1) All Forward shots are followed-up with a Strong swim by both Forwards, to ensure the opponent is trapped between the two Forward's pinch.

(2) If you are unsure whether or not your second Forward is down, do not chip the puck Forward. Swim Forward instead, keeping the puck on your stick. It is imperative the Forward line does not lose the puck off the top of the formation.

b) Horizontal to the second Forward.

(1) Lateral pass can be through a "figure 6" move or small pass.

(2) Second Forward must keep the puck in the vertical channel by driving or passing back to the Strong side. Again, do not lose the puck off the top of the formation.

(3) Similarly, the second Forward must resist the urge to swim off into space alone (towards the goal). This makes for an easy steal for the other teams back.

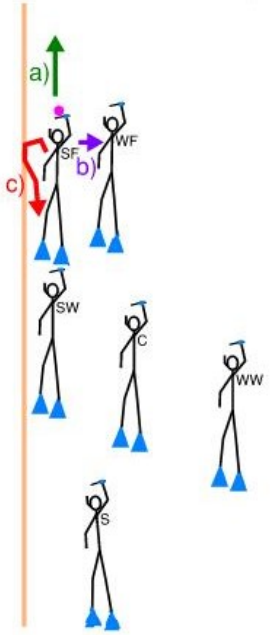
(a) Note: We will talk more about how to move from the vertical channel into a drive on goal later.

c) Curl and pass back to Strong Wing.

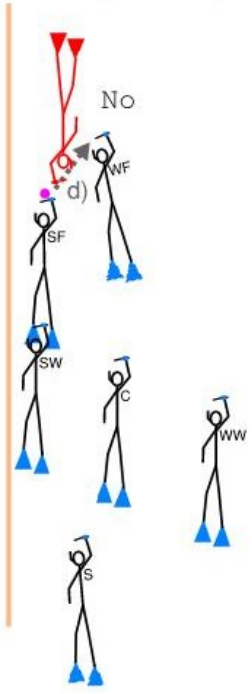
(1) This is the preferred method to avoid losing the puck off the top of the formation. Always reset puck to Center of formation (midline) before the opponent can take the puck.

d) Under no circumstances may the Forwards pass diagonally across a defender.

DIAGRAM 2-2
Strong Forward Passing Options



Never pass diagonally across a defender



3. Center passing options (See diagram 2-3):

a) Straight ahead.

(1) Chip and chase, make sure the puck gets all the way to your Forward line, so they can continue the drive.

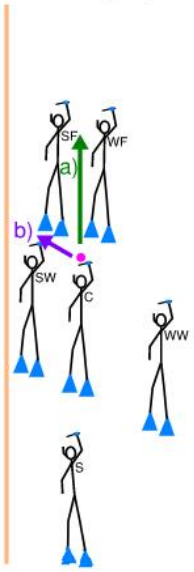
b) To the Strong Wing.

(1) This may be the Stopper if the Stopper has come in to cover the Strong Wing position. If it is the Stopper, pass and get back to cover.

c) Always swim first.

(1) The Center should always swim Forward at a high rate of speed taking any open space before passing.

DIAGRAM 2-3
Center Passing Options



C. WHITEBOARD - "CH 2.1 – Vertical Passing Drills": Practice on dryland first then get in the water to repeat the drills. All players drop and remain in formation, swimming together as a unit. Mid-line keeps the 30° line. Unless otherwise noted, all players must stay submerged until the entire passing pattern is completed.

<u>Strong Wing passing drill</u>
1. SW to C (lateral)
2. C back to SW
3. SW to SF and swim Forward
4. SF curl and pass back to SW
   *Forwards surface
5. Swim Forward, SW curl and pass to S
   *Midline surface
6. Stopper swims Forward 1-2M
   *Stopper surface and reset puck

<u>Center/Forward passing drill</u>
1. SW to C (lateral)
2. C drives Forward & passes to WF
3. WF swim & pass to SF (lateral)
4. SF swims, curls & passes back to SW
   *All players surface, SW resets puck

Rotate position every drill: (S to WW) – (WW to C) – (C to SW) – (SW to SF) – (SF to WF) – (WF to S). Every player should practice in all the positions. Practice on both sides of the pool.

D. More on the Role of the Stopper

1. The Stopper is generally behind the midline and quickly smashes anything that breaks through. The Stopper should be prepared to replace any position in the Wing line.
    a) Stopper must swim hard and fast. Take the puck and drive it forward so it is easier for the Center to drop back and cover.
        (1) Offense is the best defense.
        (2) Stopper should be engaging from a position of good visibility and therefore able to pick a swim direction that best accomplishes:
            (a) #1-team possession
            (b) #2-avoids unnecessary stick battles
            (c) #3-takes open pool
        (3) The Stopper can expect to be momentarily navigating the opposition alone, as all other players are resetting for the next push. DO NOT LOSE THE PUCK.
2. Anytime the Stopper engages, it is the Center's job to swim back and cover the Stopper position.
3. If the Stopper and Center are both beaten, the Weak Wing will cover as a last resort.

E. WHITEBOARD "CH 2.2 – Stopper Rotation": When playing near the wall, Strong Wing is the most common position that the Stopper will have to replace, because the demand is greatest here.

STOPPER ROTATION ON STRONG WALL

1. S drives into SW position and takes the puck
2. SW immediately surfaces backward, ready to re-drop behind S
    *C surfaces backward and covers S
    *WW monitors the play
3. S drives the puck Forward, if possible
    *Expect to be briefly alone against the opponent while teammates breath.
    *DO NOT LOSE THE PUCK!
4. S may pass to the Forwards or curl and return the puck to the incoming SW
5. SW, C, and WW re-enter the play in their standard 30° line
6. S returns to the back of the formation

F. WHITEBOARD - "CH 2.3 – Vertical Passing Drill with Stopper Variant": Practice on dryland first then get in the water to repeat the drills. All players drop and remain in formation, swimming together as a unit. Mid-line keeps the 30° line. Unless otherwise noted, all players must stay submerged until the entire passing pattern is completed.

Center/Forward/Stopper passing drill

1. SW to C (lateral)
2. C drives Forward & passes to WF
3. WF swim & pass to SF (lateral)
    *SW surfaces and swims back
    *Stopper takes SW position
    *C surfaces and covers Stopper
4. SF swims then curls & passes back to Stopper
    *Forwards Surface

5. Stopper swims 1-2M
    * Strong Wing re-drops
6. Stopper curls and passes to SW
    *C, WW & F's drop
7. SW passes to SF
    *All players surface, SW resets puck

Rotate position every drill: (S to WW) – (WW to C) – (C to SW) – (SW to SF) – (SF to WF) – (WF to S). Every player should practice in all the positions. Practice on both sides of the pool.

G. 2v1 Pinch (See Diagram 2-4)

1. We want to isolate opponents and create 2v1 pinches as often as possible. The pinch play can be executed by any 2 players and is not limited to any specific positions or pairs.
    a) Forward line in particular should be looking to execute 2v1 as often as possible.
    b) Only allow 1 opponent between you and your teammate.
2. The player with the puck should pass into open space, behind or "away" from an opponent, and not across the opponent's stick. The best way to accomplish this is to pass straight ahead of yourself and swim to follow-up the pass, ensuring the opponent must also swim and reach to chase the puck. Note: straight ahead of the passing player could be any direction in the pool.
    a) The receiving or pinching player should get tight to the opponent. Aligning their body to smash the puck on the front of their stick as it is pushed past the opponent.
        (1) Look for the opportunity to get close when opponent opens shoulders or stretches out.
        (2) Try not to let the opponent know you are there to maintain the element of surprise.
3. After making a pass, both players must remain down and get very tight to the opponent's body. Never let them curl 180° and swim back out between to players.

DIAGRAM 2-4
2v1 Pinch



H. Scoring Goals

1. Turning the Channel (See diagram 2-5)

a) A drive towards the goal should begin when we are 5-8M out from the goal. Drive should be initiated by the Strong Wing, Center, or Stopper. The driving player will abruptly turn and swim hard, diagonally for the goal.

(1) Always started with a swim, NOT a pass, though the puck may be passed to any player once the play is set in motion.

(2) The entire formation turns with the drive, maintaining relative positions in relation to the puck.

(3) The entire midline and both Forwards drive towards the goal, returning the puck to the Center whenever resistance is met.

(4) Forwards drop L/R in front of Center

(a) When in doubt, Forwards drop in front of the player driving the puck.

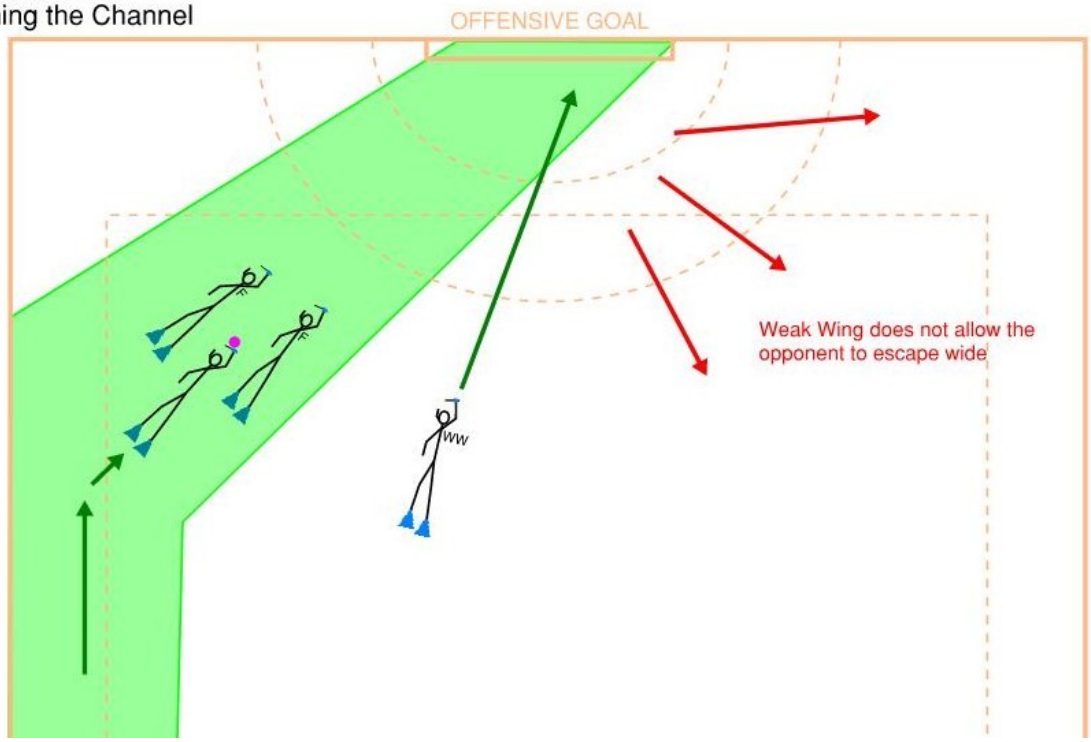
(5) It is both the Wings and the Forwards job to make sure the puck cannot escape to the L/R sides, smashing (or curling back to the Center) any puck that the opponent tries to push out of our channel and returning it to the driving channel.

(6) As we approach opponents' goal, the Weak Wing becomes very aggressive (ahead of the Center) and smashes any puck that the opponent tries to clear wide.

(7) The biggest Weakness to this scoring strategy is the opponents 45° clear out to the opposite side which might result in a breakaway goal against.

(a) Stopper should be on the lookout for this and must stop any opponents who escape the Weak Wing.

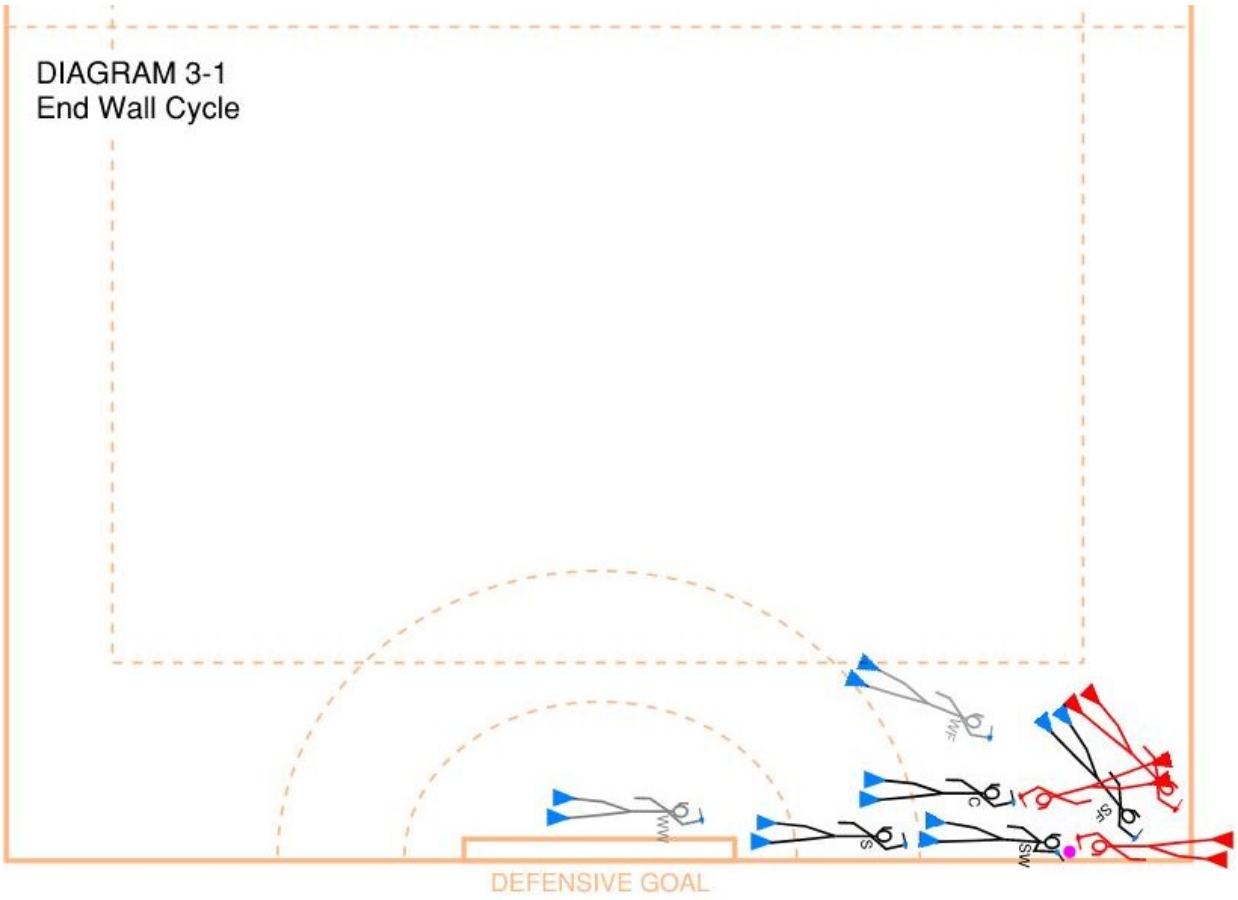
DIAGRAM 2-5
Turning the Channel



III. RED ZONE DEFENSE

A. End wall cycle (See diagram 3-1)

1. Strong Wing and Stopper cycle to defend the end wall and corner zone.
   a) Weak Wing covers the Strong Wing/Stopper in the instance both players are beaten.
2. Center remains off the wall, tight to her Wing or Stopper and defends the channel just off the wall. Center does not cover Stopper's position on the wall.
3. Forwards create chaos in the opponent's formation and separate the "stack". I.e. sandwich 1 opponent, cutting them off from the rest of their formation. Don't ever let more than one opponent between you and your team mate on the puck.



B. Defensive Trapezoid (See diagram 3-2)

1. When the opponent has possession and is attempting to drive the puck from the wall towards our goal, or possession on our defensive side wall is unclear, the Center should hold back slightly to defend the drive to our goal.

2. It is good to imagine a trapezoid in front of our goal that the Center defends by driving the puck out of this space whenever possible.

3. Center can best accomplish this by performing kelp dives, getting their hips down quickly, should they be needed to stop a drive.

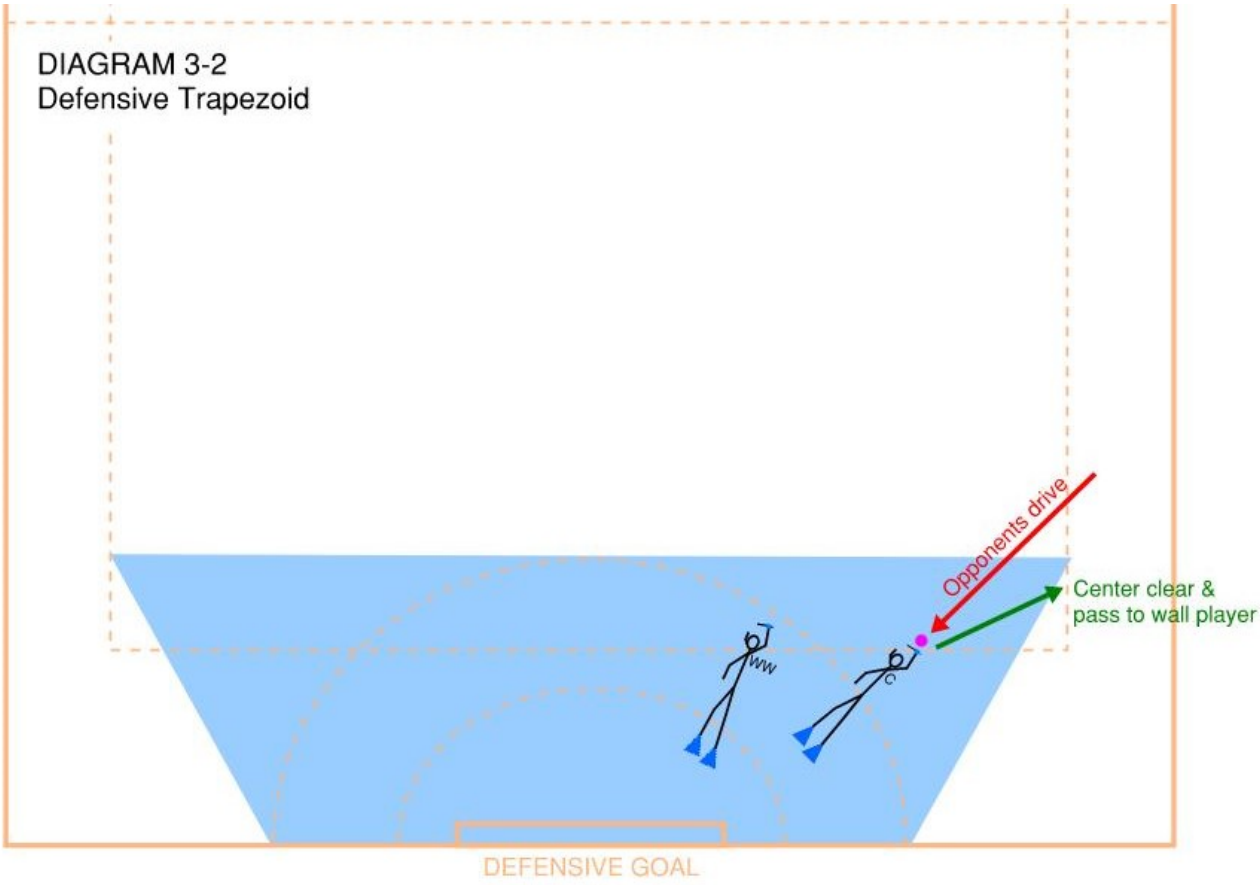
   a) Scull backwards to avoid being “sucked-in” to the wall.

   b) Pass the puck to a Wing or Forward to avoid swimming all the way to the wall.

   c) Reset quickly to defend the trapezoid again.

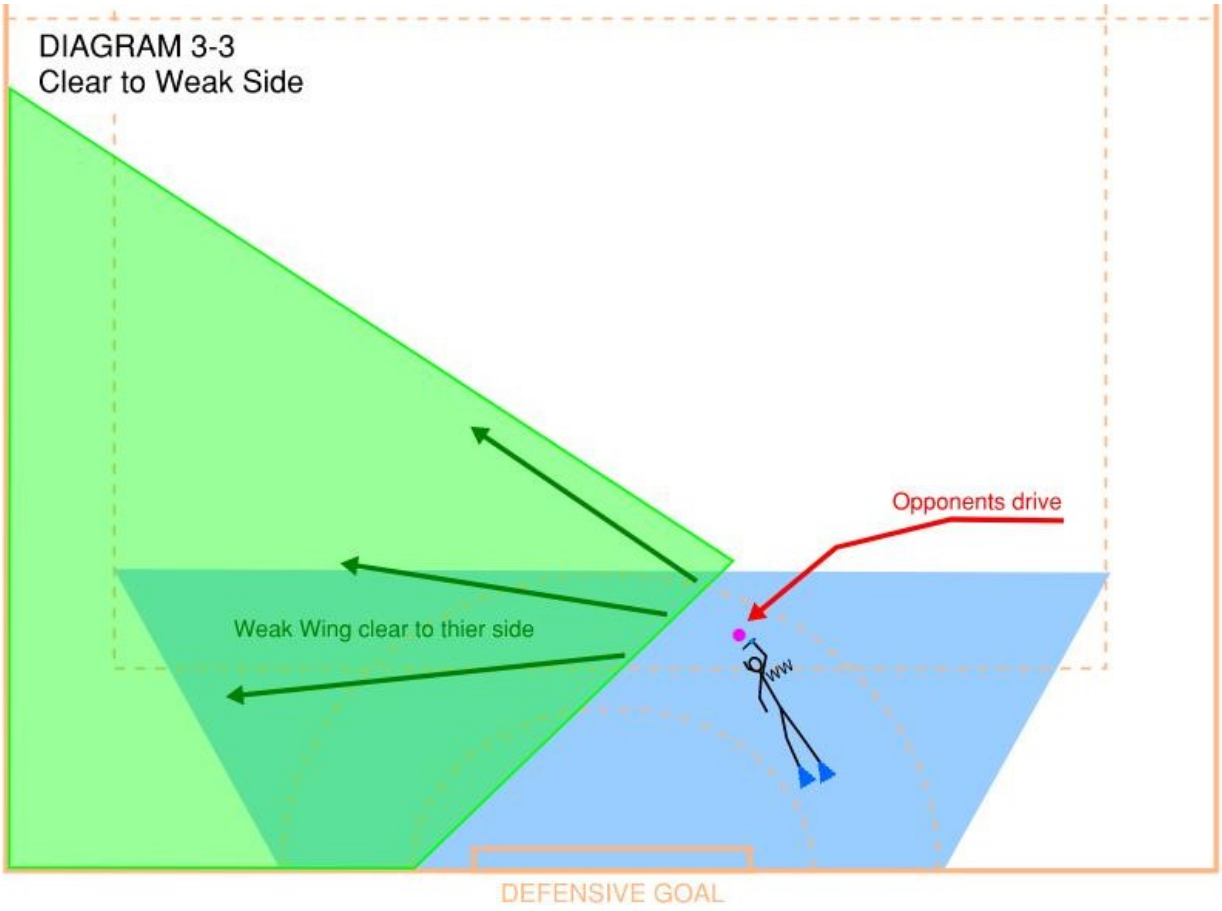
   d) Be mindful to not allow the opponents Forwards to stack up on your inside hip.

4. Weak Wing covers anything that gets through the Center.



C. Weak Wing clear to Weak side (See diagram 3-3)

1. Unlike the Center's responsibility to guard the trapezoid by driving the puck out (usually back to the strong wall), the Weak Wing is encouraged to look for any opportunities to clear the puck wide to their side whenever possible.
   a) This includes cross-goal swims.
   b) Swim fast, swim hard, don't lose the puck. Ensure it goes all the way to your side even if it ends in your defensive corner.
2. Weak Wing may tackle facing backwards, using the opponent's momentum to allows swim out and away from an opponent's drive.



D. Forward Clear (See diagram 3-4)

1. When the opposition is making repeated attempts to break through our defensive trapezoid and score, Forwards must assist with clearing the puck from the middle of our defense and driving it out towards a side wall.

2. Forwards should drive through the defense, hitting the puck with the front of their stick and swimming it out towards the open space on either side wall.

3. Forwards should swim directly out to the wall.

   a) Remember we are on defense; conservative team possession is better than allowing the opponent to steal the puck and make another drive at our goal.

      (1) If you are the only one down, hold the puck on the wall so the team can re-group.

      (2) If your partner forward is down, continue the drive up the wall, clearing the puck as far as possible out of our end before you pass back or hold.



E. Running Defense (See diagram 3-5)

1. To be used when the opposing team makes a drive down the center of the pool and we are being pushed back towards our goal.

   a) All team players swim towards our defensive goal and we maintain our standard relative positions.

   b) Center and Stopper are responsible for taking possession of the puck and distributing it to either Wing.

      (1) Center/Stopper must take possession and pass the puck off to a Wing. No stalling, stopping, or jamming backwards.

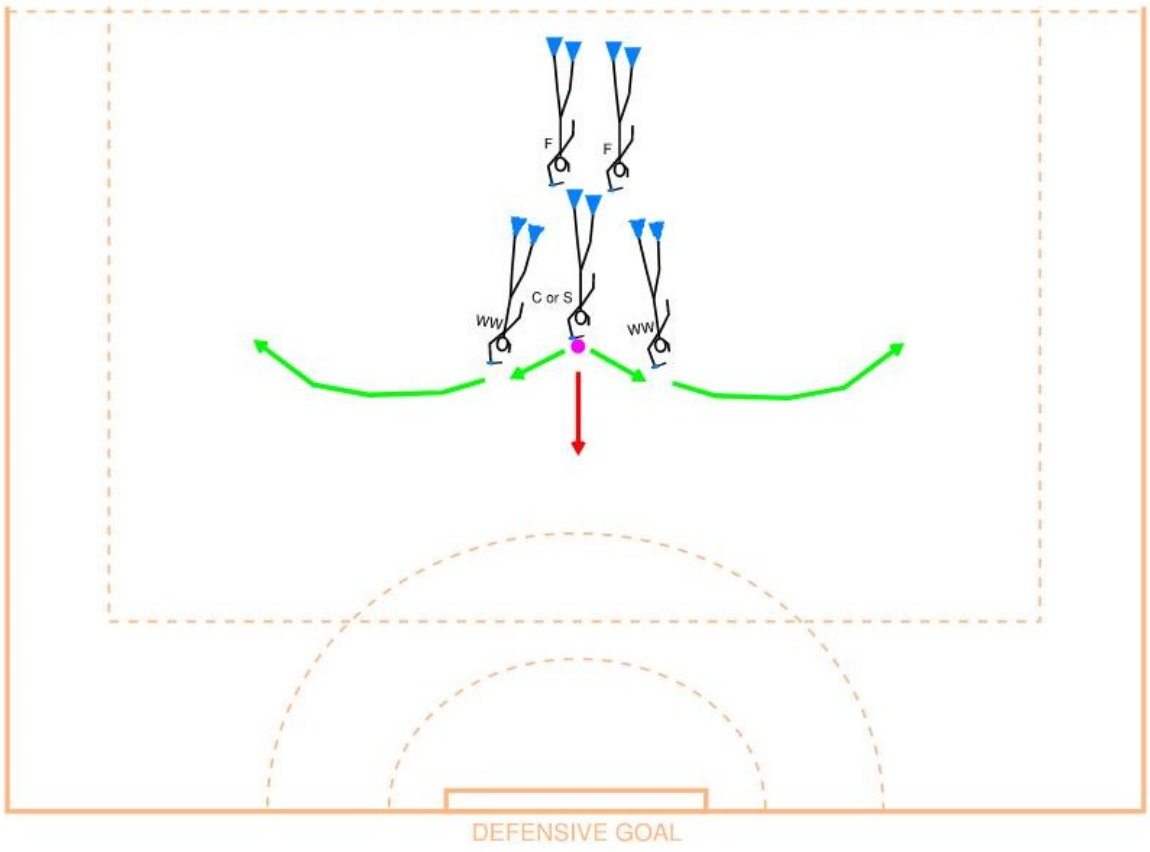
      (2) Wings must resist turning or pushing the puck back into the Center. Trust the Center/Stopper to gain possession and chip the puck in your direction, then swim away.

      (3) Forwards are creating chaos and back-picking opponents. If a Forward receives the puck in the scrum, they should swim through and pass the puck out to a Wing.

   c) Receiving Wing swims diagonally back, towards their own side before turning up pool.

   d) Forwards breath and meet the Wing (at the first defender) out in space for a 2v1 pinch.

DIAGRAM 3-5
Running Defense



F. WHITE BOARD “Ch 3.1 – Running Defense Drill”: To start this drill, we need 3 teammates (2x Wings, 1x Center/Stopper) and 3 opponents. The roll of the Center/Stopper is interchangeable here and will be performed by whichever player is available, sometimes both if the initial effort fails.

All players (teammates and opponents) start relatively lateral, behind the puck, facing the team’s defensive goal.

Running Defense Drill

1. Opponent 1 takes the puck and swims (slowly) towards the goal, opponents 2 & 3 are at their left and right hip, forming an arrowhead drive towards our goal.
2. Center/Stopper dives over the top of the opponent (chasing the puck). Wings dive and swim backwards maintaining their left/right sides.
3. Center/Stopper steals the puck and passes diagonally, towards our defensive corner and towards either left or right Wing.

*Center/Stopper make sure to hit the puck and not the opponent.

*Wing, trust your Center/Stopper, you can get close but do not push/jam the puck back through the Center. Maintain a backwards facing position, towards our own goal.

4. Wing receives the pass and takes several Strong kicks backwards, out, and around. Swimming in an arc to clear the puck off the opponents drive. The arc must be wide enough to get outside the opponent on that side!

Drill ends when Wing clears the puck wide.

Note: Opponents start very slow, a.k.a. “Dummy D” on this one. It is a challenging tackle to make when Center/Stopper is first learning.

G. Discuss Center Stopper Tackling options

1. “Knife” Swim off.
2. “Monkey grip” tackle.

H. We will repeat Running Defense Drill in the future, adding additional outside opponents and teammate Forwards. Speed will increase with successful clears.

IV. WON STRIKE PLAYS

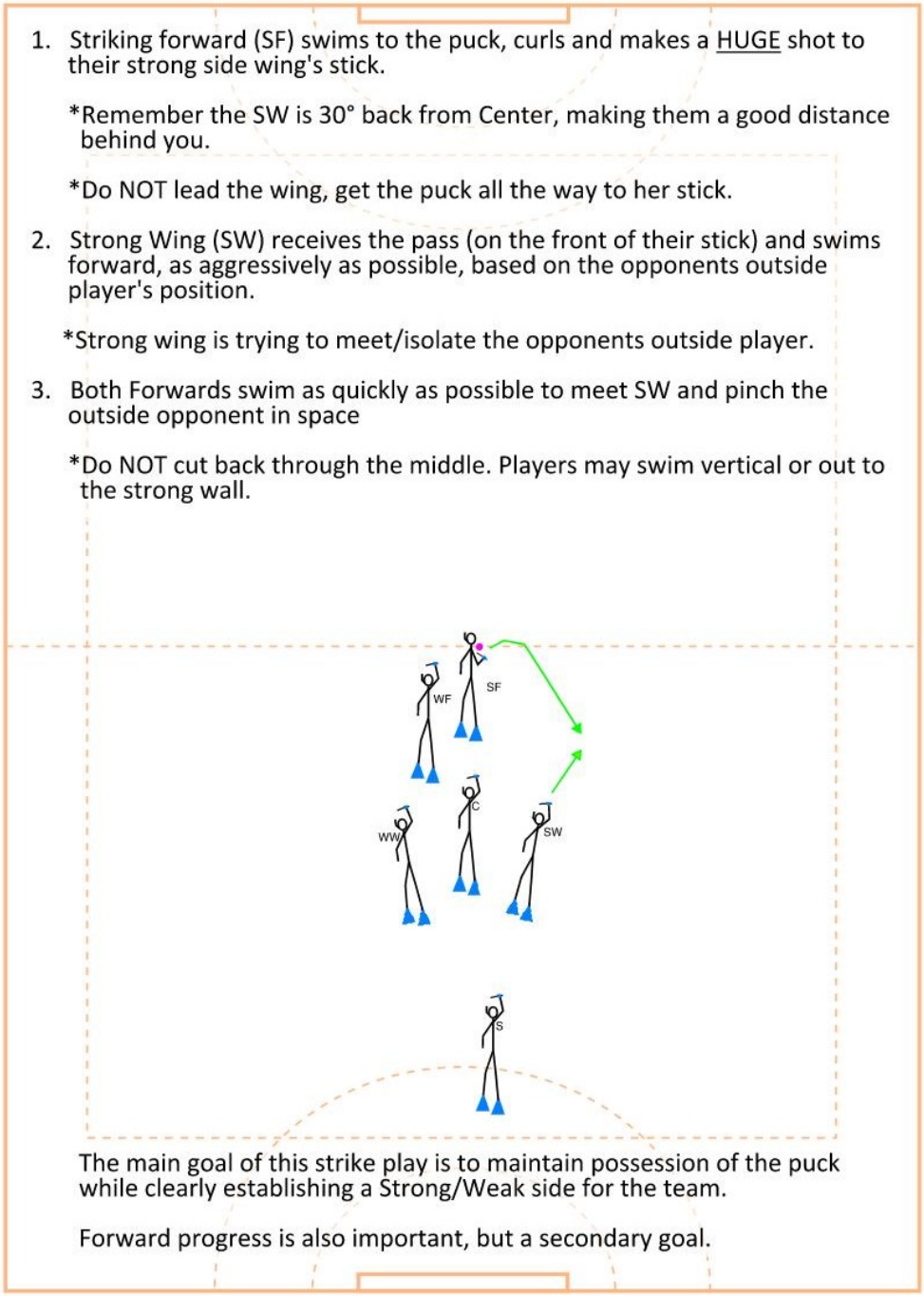
A. Forward to same side Wing strike play (See Diagram 4-1)

1. This is our go-to rush.

2. This is a good option if striking Forward is faster than the 2nd Forward.

3. Striking Forward may be left or right Forward (diagram shows right side = Strong side).

Diagram 4-1
Forward to Wing Strike Play



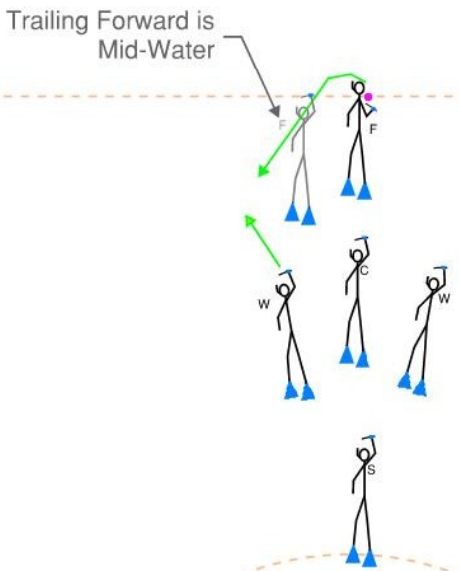
B. Forward to CROSS side Wing strike play (See Diagram 4-2)

1. All the points from the previous rush apply. ADDITIONALLY: the second (a.k.a. trailing) Forward must allow the shot to travel beneath them. Do not intercept the pass to your Wing. Trailing Forward is either mid-water or on the bottom. If they are on the bottom, they should "arch-up" quickly to allow the shot to the Wing when the striking Forward turns to curl.

Diagram 4-2
Forward to CROSS Wing Strike Play

1. Striking forward swims to the puck, curls and makes a HUGE shot to their off-side wing's stick.
2. Offside wing receives the pass (on the front of their stick) and swims forward, as aggressively as possible, based on the opponents outside player's position.
3. Since trailing forward is mid-water for this strike, they should be able to turn and swim directly for their wing pinch, as soon as the striking forwards pass is made (do not go up for breath).

*Striking forward can breath and re-drop as soon as possible.



This play works well as it allows the striking forward a quick breath of air before re-joining the play.

It also creates a shorter swim for the trailing forward to get into position.

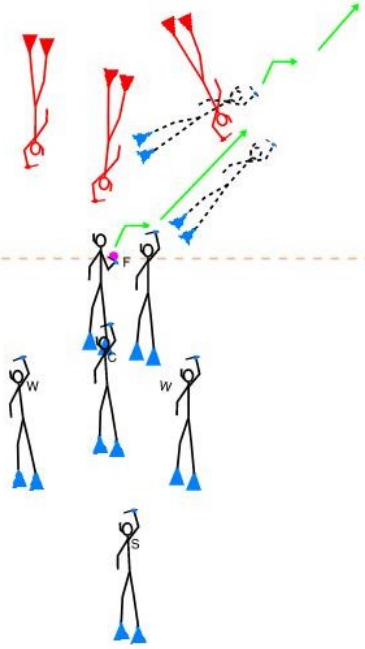
C. Forward to Forward strike play (See Diagram 4-3)

1. This strike is for aggressive forward movement.

2. Assumes both Forwards are similar speed and will be driving fast!

Diagram 4-3
Forward to Forward Strike Play

1. The striking forward swims to the puck, sliding it laterally to their partner forward.
2. Both forwards stay down and swim forward hard, trying to create a 2v1 pinch on the first outside opponent they meet. Striking forward jumps over opponent to create the pinch.
3. Forwards continue to pinch outside opponents until they can no longer drive together.
4. BEFORE loosing puck possession, either forward should lay-it back to the Strong Wing (SW), breath and reset for their next drop.



The main goal with this strike play is to be pressuring the opponents last back as quickly as possible in a 2v1 pinch.

This play can be very effective against a 3-3 formation.

V. OPEN PLAY

A. Ideally, we want to always play a fast-swimming game, where we control the movement of the puck and feel comfortable playing in the open pool. We practice this by swimming and passing into space. Instead of battling multiple opponents at once, we try to isolate and stretch each opponent, forcing them each into 2v1 pinches between our teammates.

1. Space can exist anywhere in the pool; it is not limited to the center section. Some previously discussed examples of finding space at the wall or wall channel include:
    a) Passing patterns using vertical shots to the space behind opponents on the wall.
    b) Forward clearing our congested red zone to space on wall.
    c) Running defense play to clear opponent's center drive out to space on wall.
2. When space is not available in the current position, we will swim to find it in another section of the pool.
3. Unless we know and have discussed otherwise (for a specific match) we will always work to move the puck into open space, wherever it can be found.

B. Crossing through the center of the pool to find space (a.k.a "Swing" or "Switch").

1. The cross-pool swim may be performed by any player, however, we are going to practice the Weak Wing variant until we are great at it, because it is the safest option.
    a) This play usually includes a pass, out to the Weak Wing and is followed by a cross-pool swim into the open space on the opposite side of the pool.
    b) We are eliminating a Weak Forward swim option at this time.
    c) All off-wall plays will be initiated by the midline or Stopper.
2. The swim may be performed left to right or right to left.
    a) In addition to just finding space, we will use the location of the team's and opponent's sub boxes to help decide when a cross pool swim is appropriate.
        (1) Cross pool to our sub box to refresh our lineup.
        (2) Cross pool to the far side of the pool away from our opponent's sub box.

3. Prior to swimming cross pool, the Weak Wing should be constantly checking the position of the opponent's outside player. Assessing how quickly that opponent may engage, during a cross pool swim. This will determine your swim angle.

   a) Swim as aggressively as is allowed to isolate the opponent's outside player.

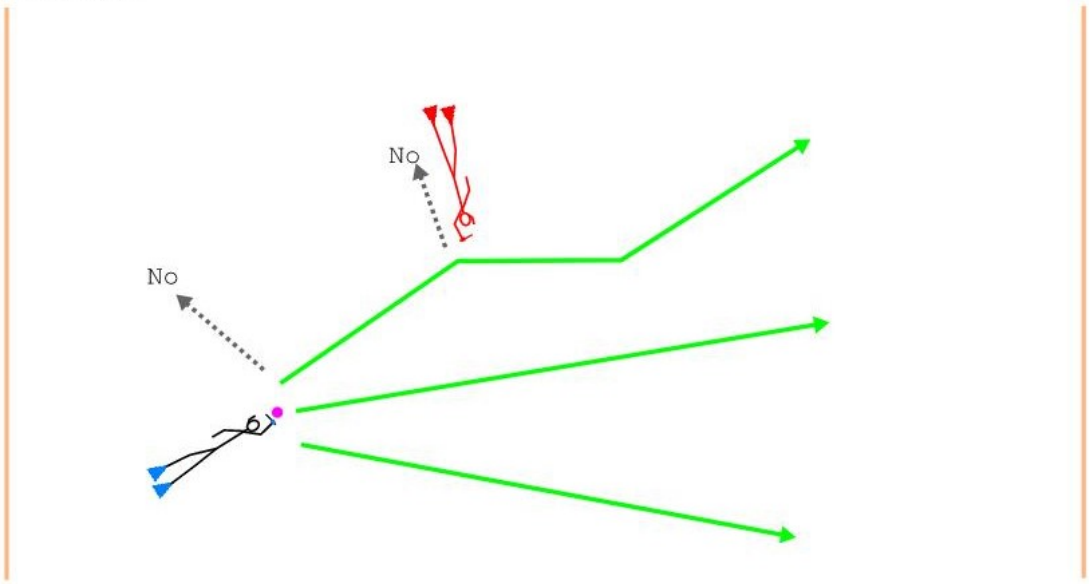
   b) Player may swim diagonally Forward, laterally, or diagonally backwards (Refer to diagram 5-1).

      (1) Do not turn back towards the Strong side.

      (2) Do not attempt to beat an opponent on their inside.

      (3) The only exception to the "no-turn-back" rule is when we are in the opponents red zone. Wing may curl or pass back to Center the puck in front of the opponent's goal.

DIAGRAM 5-1
Cross Pool Swim

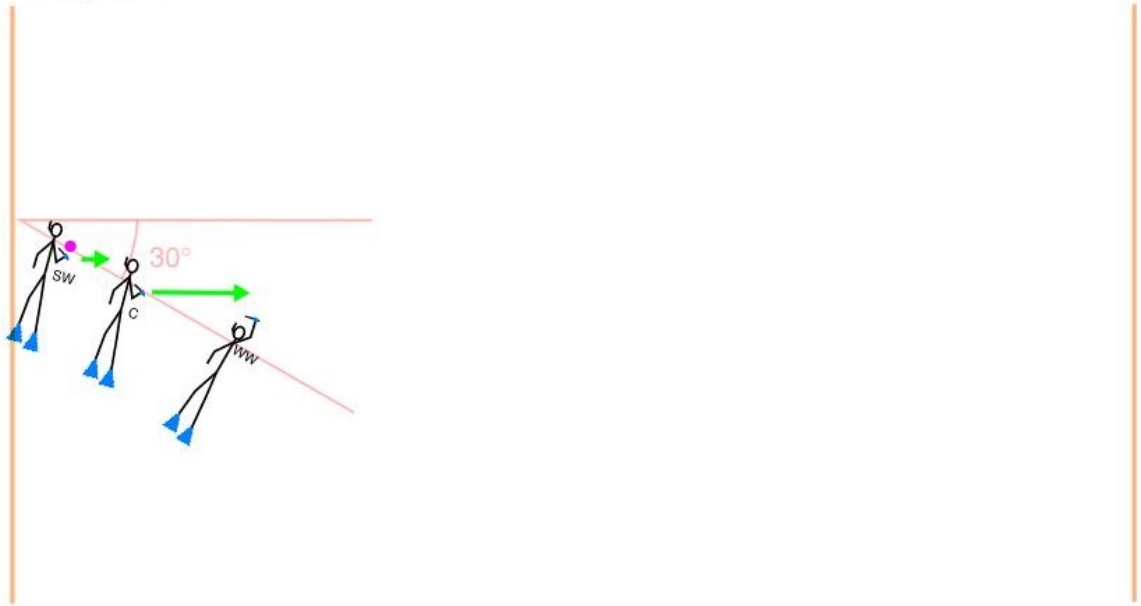


4. It is the responsibility of the swimming player to keep possession of the puck while crossing the pool. They may:
    a) Swim backward to retain puck possession against an aggressive opponent.
    b) Temporarily face up pool or employ other techniques to slow the opponent and allow their incoming Forward time to dive for the 2v1 pinch.
    c) Curl and pass backward to an incoming teammate (Center or Stopper) after they have stretched the opponent's outside player.
5. It is the responsibility of the passing player to get the puck directly into the Weak Wing's control.
    a) Do not force the wing to swim after a puck shot slightly up pool or place the puck in a situation where they have to race an opponent to get to a landed pass first.

C. Passing out to the Weak Wing through the midline (See diagram 5-2).

1. This is a fast and flat (lateral) passing pattern.
2. Strong Wing and Center swim/pass the puck laterally out to the Weak Wing.
    a) This play relies on quick movement and passes.
    b) Center and Weak Wing may anticipate lateral motion by turning their bodies towards the center or opening up to space on the Weak side.
    c) Passing player may turn and swim while passing the puck, which results in a forward shot, laterally in the pool.

DIAGRAM 5-2
Open through midline

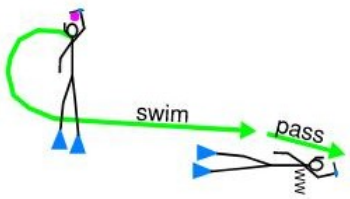


D. Opening through a curl and swim (often performed by the Stopper, See diagram 5-3).

1. Player curls towards the Strong wall, keeping the puck in a protected position, then swims out laterally and towards the Weak Wing, who drops in front of them for a Forward pass, laterally in the pool.

a) Be careful to place the puck in a position that the Weak Wing can hit it at high speed directly in front of their drive.

DIAGRAM 5-3
Open Through Curl & Swim

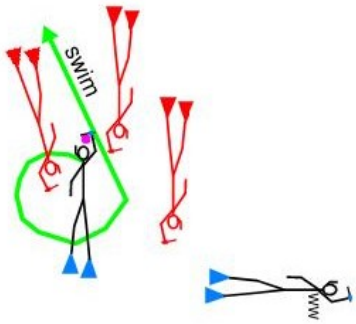


b) Be ready to turn back and battle up your Strong wall if your “swim out” becomes covered during your curl (See diagram 5-4).

(1) Split the defenders. Escape is through the opponents, diagonally forward, up the Strong wall.

(2) A quick tumble turn or hinge with your body may be required to complete the quick change of direction back to Strong wall that splits incoming opponents.

DIAGRAM 5-4
Split the Opponents



E. Forwards leave the bottom immediately when they sense a swing is starting.

1. Breath and meet the swimming player at the first opponent for a 2v1 pinch.

2. Hustle, Hustle, Hustle – surface at an angle and sprint.

F. WHITE BOARD "Ch5.1– Wing/Forward 2v1 Pinch Drill": For this drill we will require 3 lines of players.

Player 1 (Wing): Line starts 4-5M off wall, anywhere mid-pool.
Player 2 (Forward): Line starts up pool and slightly behind Wing.
Player 3 (Opponent): Line starts beyond Forward line, directly up pool from Wing.

Wing/Forward 2v1 Pinch Drill

1. Wing starts with puck and swims diagonally Forward, towards the wall.
    * Opponent swims at the Wing.
    * Forward swims over the top of the opponent.
2. Wing turns up pool (open shoulders to look up pool) before the opponent is on them. Keep the puck on the front of your stick.
    * Opponent mirrors the Wing.
    * Forward uses this time to keep swimming into place.
3. Wing accelerates fast towards the wall and passes puck into space (also towards the wall).
4. Wing will follow shot, forcing the opponent to:
    * Stretch towards puck and curl away from the Wing.
5. Forward hits the puck with the front of their stick as the opponents curls away from the Wing.
6. Forward turns and swims 1-2M up pool. Using only the front of the stick to control the puck.

The drill is complete.

*Forward resets the puck and joins the back of the Wing line.
*Opponent moves to back of Forward line.
*Wing move to back of Opponent line.

VI. EQUAL/ADVANTAGE/DISADVANTAGE

A. Players ready and on the bottom as play is restarting is MORE IMPORTANT than any strategy.

1. Watch the in-water refs and drop as the line is set, and they both raise their hands.

2. If in doubt, don't discuss or delay. Just ensure you are on the correct side of the ref line, get down and play your position.

3. Do not sub on an advantage, disadvantage, or equal puck at the 5M line of either goal.

4. Clear team possession in the seconds following any stoppage is our #1 goal.

B. Advantage Puck

1. Except in specific situations, noted below, standard position setup applies. Both Forwards down (at the ref line), midline down with Center at the puck and Wings on 30°, Stopper is on surface or mid-pool, watching.

2. The Center always takes the puck and has three play options (See diagram 6-1):

a) Center swims Forward, and

(1) passes to Strong Wing

(2) passes to Forwards

b) Center swims lateral to begin cross pool swing and passes to Weak Wing.

3. Center may execute any of the above-mentioned plays. They will use the opponent's setup and our relative position in the pool to make smart decisions (See Diagram 6-1 – left/right sides are interchangeable).

a) Defensive End – Our preferred play is to swim forward and pass to the Strong Wing.

(1) Center may also pass to Forwards sometimes as way to ensure the opponent continues to dedicate players to guard that position, or when the opponent is slow to the bottom/subbing.

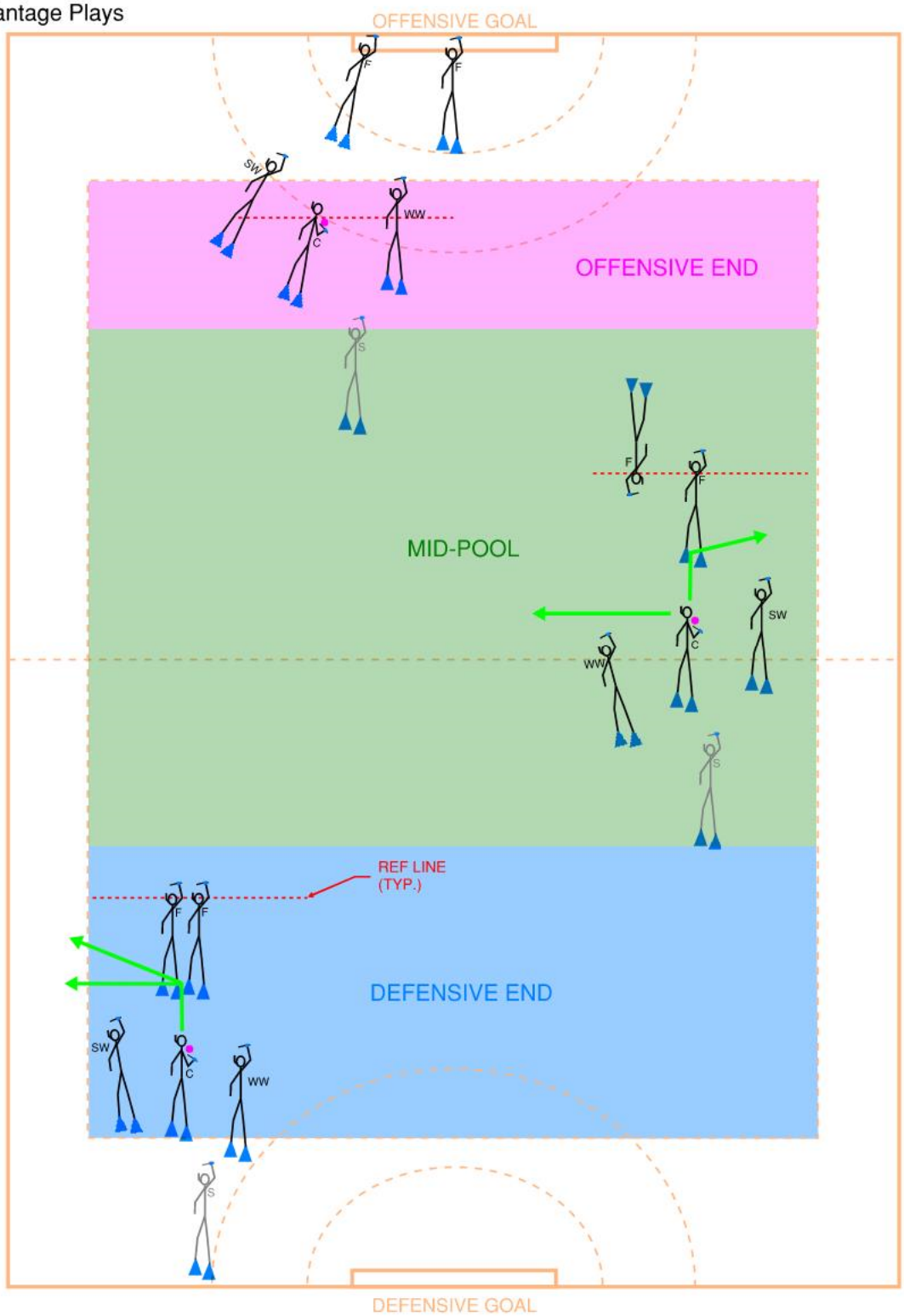
(2) Center may also choose to swing cross pool if we really need to get out in space, change the strong side, or want to bring the puck to our sub box for fresh players.

b) Mid Pool – Our preferred plays are to either swing cross pool to the Weak Wing or to swim forward and pass to the Strong Wing.

(1) Center may pass up to Strong Forward in the cases mentioned above.

(2) Whenever we have an advantage mid pool, the Forwards will adjust setup with the strong side facing forward and the weak side facing backwards towards their own midline.

Diagram 6-1
Advantage Plays



c) Offensive End – Our preferred play is to swim and pass up to the Forwards

(1) Only pass to Strong Wing or swing cross pool if the opponent is strongly guarding our forward drive and leaving space to the outsides.

(2) In front of the opponent's goal the Forwards should move forward of the ref line and occupy space in the goal trough, choosing any position that best breaks up the opponent's defense.

(a) In this situation scoring immediately becomes our #1 goal.

(b) Forwards get tough, this is one of the hardest positions in the game, no opponent is going to let you into this space willingly, just keep burrowing down and break up their back line. Get mad, but do not get caught fouling an opponent.

(3) Wings will set up in the space between the center and the ref line, swimming into the space and may receive a forward pass from the Center.

(a) Wings are responsible to ensure the puck stays in front of the opponent's goal and may adjust their position accordingly.

(b) Return the puck back to the space immediately in front of the opponents goal any time the opponents try to escape wide.

(i) Use Monkey Grip Tackle or Figure 6

C. Disadvantage Puck

1. On all disadvantage pucks, Forwards are down just behind the ref line and in front of the puck, Midline is down with both Wings lateral to the Center. The Stopper chooses their position behind the team based on how close we are to the defensive end.

2. Immediately as the opponent touches the puck both Forwards will rush in to take it.

    a) The Forwards will stagger their positions slightly, based on our relative left/right position in the pool.

        (1) Strong Forward is always slightly ahead, and Weak Forward is always slightly behind.

        (2) If the play is Centered in the pool, left Forward is slightly ahead and right Forward is slightly behind.

    b) If a Forward successfully steals the puck they should swim and take as much space as possible, then pass back to the midline.

    c) If the Forwards miss the puck they should curl and attempt to back pick immediately, passing the puck out the Wings to reset if they take possession.

3. Center follows the Forward line and also attempts to aggressively take the puck.

    a) If the Center receives or takes the puck, they should distribute out to either Wing immediately.

    b) On the 5M line in front of our defensive goal the Center will play very aggressively swimming the puck away from the goal, out into space if they gain control (Do not distribute the puck to the Wings until you have completely cleared the goal).

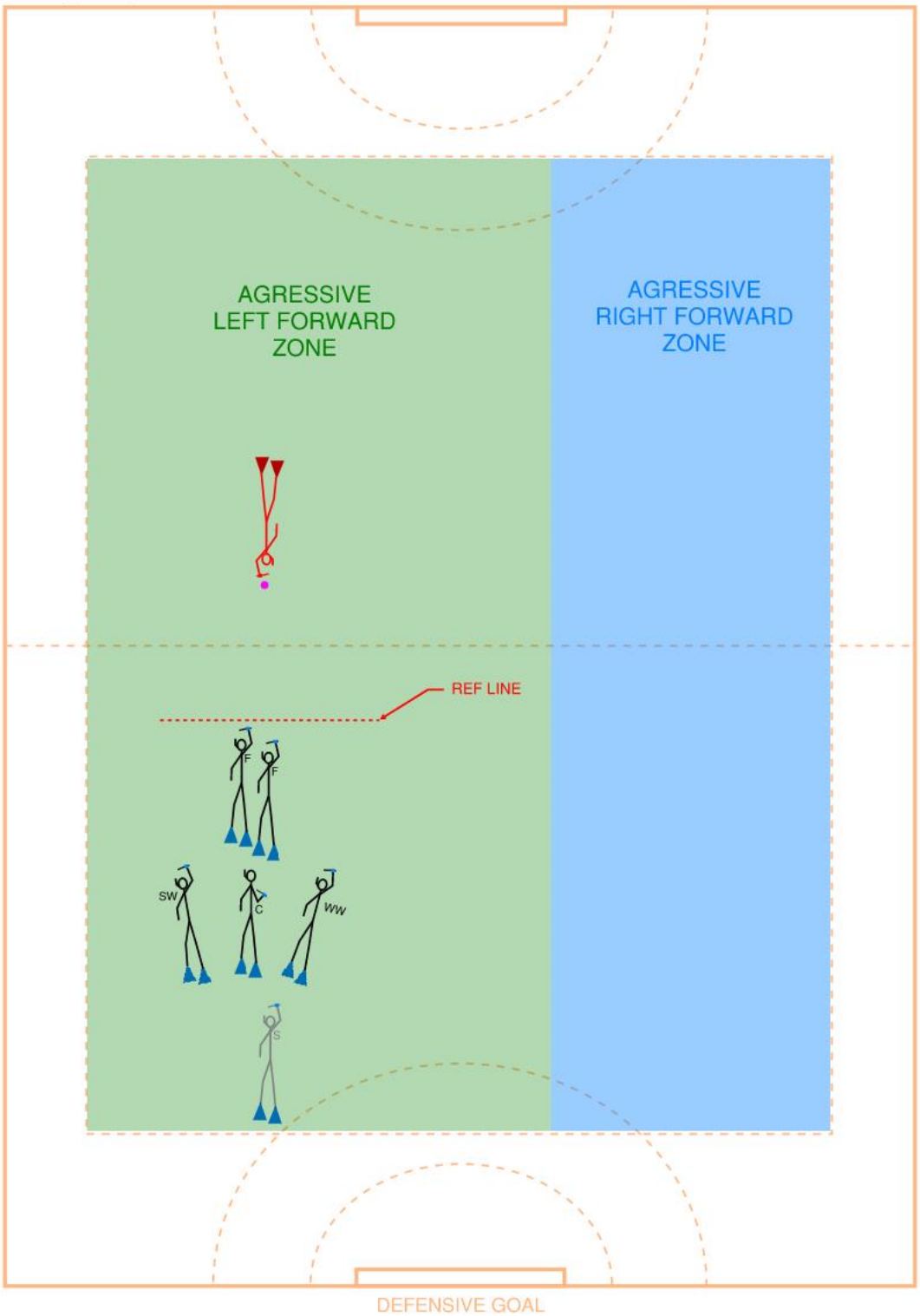
4. Lateral Wing Line

    a) Wings are looking for the best position to be hidden (not look intimidating) in the vertical channel, but also prepared to swim very fast and shut down the opponents swing play immediately.

        (1) Wings may continue to swim forward towards the ref line after the opponents have dropped and before they touch the puck.

    b) If the opponent drives straight into our line, beating both our Forwards and Center, the Wings should curl towards the play swimming backwards for Running Defense Play.

Diagram 6-2
Disadvantage Plays



D. Equal Puck

1. Players have same setup for equal puck as disadvantage puck.
2. Strong side Forward goes for the puck and Weak side drops straight down.
3. Won Equal pucks:
    a) Strong Forward shoves puck directly to their Strong Wing and jumps ahead for an immediate 2v1 pinch.
    b) Weak Forward drops with Strong Forward (momentarily using their body to block the opponent's vision) then also jumps ahead to pair with their Strong Forward on a vertical drive.
4. Lost Equal Pucks:
    a) Both Forwards immediately try to take possession of the puck either by either
        (1) Swimming Forward and putting immediate 2v1 pressure on the opponent receiving a back pass from their Forward, or
        (2) Curling to back pick, Forwards should pass the puck out the Wings immediately and reset if they get control.

VII. GAME AWARENESS & VIDEO DISCUSSION TOPICS

A. “Slow your roll” vs. “go time”

B. Decompressing the lines

C. Subbing

D. Game Clock, Score, Risk taking